million books a year," David Craven points out. "By 1980 it published over fifty million books a year, all of which were sold below production costs, with school textbooks being free to all students … In 1962, the National Council on Culture sponsored events attended by four million spectators, or almost half the population. During 1975, the Cuban government sponsored events in the arts that were attended by 67 million spectators, almost seven times the national population."[6]

Of course cultural change is difficult to measure. One set of data that we can use to add to the discussion is surveys of popular opinion. A survey carried out in the spring of 1960 found an astonishing 86 percent of the population claiming to support the revolutionary government, with 43 percent showing "fervent" support.[7] These figures surely illustrate the degree to which the Revolution, and the popular mobilizations succeeded in capturing the imaginations of ordinary Cubans, indicating just the kind of cultural change that the Revolution sought to create. Over time, however, the overlap between cultural change and explicit support for the government probably became less obvious. If education, participation, and raised political consciousness were central to the revolutionary project of cultural transformation, then a vigorous debate about political and social realities could be seen as evidence of the project's success.

As we have seen above, one arena for such a debate is among intellectuals, in universities and research institutions. But intellectuals have always participated in this kind of conversation – it is their bread and butter. What about the rest of society, the ordinary people whose lives, ideas, and beliefs the Revolution sought to so radically transform?

Both Fagen and Bunck look at the creation and transformation of culture from the top down. Sujatha Fernandes, in contrast, argues that the Cuban state is "not a repressive centralized apparatus that enforces its dictates on citizens from the top down" but rather "a permeable entity that both shapes and is constituted by the activities of various social actors." "Artistic public spheres" are one of the means by which ordinary Cubans participate, debate, and critique political and social realities.[8] Fernandes's approach transcends the dichotomy that emerges